

11+ Comprehension - Sample Paper

GL Assessment format | 659 words | 8 questions | 16 marks

659 words · 8 questions · 16 marks · target: GL Assessment (400-800 word passage)

Passage

The house smelled of old wood and regret. Mira stood in the doorway of her grandfather's cottage, one hand gripping her mother's sleeve, the other pressed flat against the peeling doorframe. She had never met the man who lived here. All she knew of Edmund Baxter was a faded photograph on her mother's dressing table: a stern face beneath a flat cap, eyes like chips of November sky. She had assumed, somehow, that he must simply not care.

"Five minutes," her mother said softly, the words more apology than instruction. "Just to check on him." The hallway was narrow and dim, crammed with wellington boots, stacked newspapers, and a coat rack bowed under the weight of decades. Mira trailed behind her mother through a kitchen that smelled of buttered toast and something floral - perhaps lavender - and out through the back door into a garden where a separate building stood apart from the house like a shy afterthought. A low, sturdy shed, its windows grimy with cobwebs, its moss-furred roof sagging gently at one end as though it had grown tired of standing straight.

Inside, Mira stopped breathing.

Every surface, every shelf, every windowsill held a bird. Not real birds - carved ones, each whittled from pale, smooth wood and painted with extraordinary care. The detail was astonishing. A robin puffed its terracotta chest on the top shelf. Below it, a curlew stretched its improbable beak towards the ceiling. In the corner, a pair of starlings faced each other as if engaged in some private conversation, their purple-green plumage rendered in patient, minute brushstrokes. The workshop smelled of sawdust and linseed oil, and winter light fell through the cobwebbed panes in long, dust-laden shafts.

Mira moved closer. On the workbench lay tools she could not name - curved knives, fine chisels, small hammers worn smooth with use. Pale wood shavings curled at her feet like strange, shed leaves. She picked one up and turned it over between her fingers, marvelling that she was holding the ghost of something that had once been entirely formless.

A half-finished bird sat clamped in a vice. Its shape was still rough and blunt, yet Mira could already see the eventual creature hidden within the block - the tucked wings, the alert tilt of the head, the implication of a tail. She reached out, then pulled her hand back sharply, uncertain whether touching it would be a kind of trespassing.

That was when she saw the shelf above the door.

Lined up neatly, separated from the other birds by a deliberate gap, were five small carved figures. Different species, different sizes - a wren, a swallow, a yellowhammer, a swift, a goldfinch - but each one had a small tag tied around its neck with a loop of twine. Mira stood on her tiptoes and read the label on the nearest one. A single word in cramped, elderly handwriting.

Mira.

Her chest tightened sharply. She checked the next tag. Mira. And the next. All five birds on that shelf bore her name. Five birds she had never seen. Five birds in a shed she had never visited, made by hands she had never shaken, by a man who - according to every adult conversation she had ever half-overheard - had simply walked out of the family and never looked back.

Mira sat down heavily on the workbench stool, the wood cold through her jeans, and stared at the shelf until her vision blurred.

When her mother appeared in the doorway a moment later, her face held a complicated expression that Mira had no word for yet.

"He's been making them," Mira said, her voice barely above a quiet whisper. "Every single year."

Her mother crossed the workshop in three swift steps and pulled Mira against her without a word. Above them, the carved birds stood in their quiet rows, patient and very still, keeping their own long vigil in the thin winter light.

Questions

1. (1 mark) According to the passage, what did each of the five birds on the special shelf have tied around its neck?
 2. (1 mark) The passage describes 'a curlew stretched its improbable beak towards the ceiling'. What does the word 'improbable' mean as it is used here?
 3. (1 mark) Write the missing word to complete this sentence from the passage: 'She reached out, then pulled her hand back _____, uncertain whether touching it would be a kind of trespassing.'
 4. (2 marks) What can you infer about Edmund Baxter's feelings towards Mira, even before she reads the labels on the birds? Use evidence from the passage and explain what it shows.
 5. (3 marks) Look at this sentence from the passage: 'Pale wood shavings curled at her feet like strange, shed leaves.' Identify the language technique used, quote the relevant words, and explain the effect this has on the reader.
 6. (3 marks) Compare how Mira thinks about her grandfather at the beginning of the passage with how she thinks about him at the end. Your answer should include both a similarity and a difference, supported by evidence from the text.
 7. (3 marks) In no more than 50 words, summarise what Mira discovers in the workshop and what she realises as a result. Use your own words as much as possible. Descriptive detail will not be rewarded.
 8. (2 marks) What can you infer about how Mira's mother feels when she appears in the doorway near the end of the passage? Use evidence from the text and explain what it shows.
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Mark Scheme

Parent/teacher copy. Award each numbered point separately - partial credit is the point.

1. (1 mark) - retrieval

- *Rule:* 1 mark = one accurate point, quoted or closely paraphrased. Precision scores; generality does not.

- *Key quote*: "each one had a small tag tied around its neck with a loop of twine"
- *Accept (1 mark each)*:
- Award 1 mark for: a (small) tag / a label. Also accept: a loop of twine. The answer must be specific; do not accept vague answers such as 'something' or 'a decoration'.
- *Full-mark model answer*: Each of the five birds had a small tag tied around its neck with a loop of twine.

2. (1 mark) - vocabulary

- *Rule*: 1 mark = the meaning OF THE WORD IN THIS PASSAGE. A dictionary definition scores nothing.
- *Key quote*: "improbable beak"
- *Accept (1 mark each)*:
- Award 1 mark for any of: surprisingly long / unexpectedly large / out of proportion / almost too long to seem real / comically oversized. Do NOT accept 'impossible'. Do NOT accept a general dictionary definition that is not tied to the physical appearance of the beak in this passage.
- *Full-mark model answer*: In this context, 'improbable' means that the curlew's beak looks so remarkably long it seems almost too large to be real - as though it is out of proportion and barely believable.

3. (1 mark) - cloze

- *Rule*: 1 mark = the single word that fits the gap in context.
- *Key quote*: "pulled her hand back sharply"
- *Accept (1 mark each)*:
- Award 1 mark for: sharply. No other answer is acceptable.
- *Full-mark model answer*: sharply

4. (2 marks) - inference

- *Rule*: 2 marks = inference + evidence + explanation. Stating the inference alone scores 1 at most.
- *Key quote*: "separated from the other birds by a deliberate gap"
- *Accept (1 mark each)*:
- 1 mark - Inference: Despite being absent from Mira's life, Edmund has been keeping her in mind and caring about her in secret. Stating only that he carved birds is insufficient; the pupil must make a judgement about what this reveals about his feelings.
- 1 mark - Evidence and explanation: e.g. the five birds are 'separated from the other birds by a deliberate gap', showing they were set apart on purpose - this suggests Edmund made a conscious decision to distinguish birds made for Mira from all the others, revealing private affection. OR: Mira has 'never met the man' and he is said to have 'walked out of the family', yet five birds exist bearing her name - the contrast between his apparent abandonment and the existence of these birds shows a hidden, continuing attachment. The pupil must both cite or closely paraphrase evidence AND explain what it reveals to earn this second mark.
- *Full-mark model answer*: I can infer that Edmund has secretly cared about Mira and been thinking about her, even though he has not been part of her life. The evidence is that the five birds labelled with

her name are 'separated from the other birds by a deliberate gap', which shows he kept them apart on purpose. This tells us he saw these birds as something different and special - not just carvings, but a private connection to his granddaughter that he chose to maintain even in silence.

5. (3 marks) - language

- *Rule:* 3 marks = name the technique, quote it, explain the effect on the reader.
- *Key quote:* "like strange, shed leaves"
- *Accept (1 mark each):*
- 1 mark - Technique correctly identified: simile. Do not accept 'metaphor' or 'imagery' alone.
- 1 mark - Relevant words quoted: 'like strange, shed leaves'. The comparative phrase must be included; accept without the comma between 'strange' and 'shed'.
- 1 mark - Effect on the reader explained: any of the following earn this mark: it makes the workshop feel natural and almost living, as though beautiful things are constantly growing and being shed there; the word 'strange' creates a slightly eerie or magical quality that makes the reader share Mira's sense of wonder; it transforms what might seem like waste into something poetic, reflecting the passage's theme of hidden beauty; it creates a vivid, tactile picture that places the reader in the scene. The answer must address the effect on the reader, not simply describe what the simile compares.
- *Full-mark model answer:* The writer uses a simile, comparing the wood shavings to 'like strange, shed leaves'. This creates the impression that the workshop is almost alive and natural - as if beautiful things are constantly growing and falling away there, just as leaves fall from trees. The word 'strange' also gives the scene a slightly mysterious, magical quality that makes the reader share Mira's feeling that she has stepped into somewhere truly extraordinary.

6. (3 marks) - comparison

- *Rule:* 3 marks = both similarities and differences, each with textual evidence.
- *Accept (1 mark each):*
- 1 mark - Difference: at the beginning Mira believes her grandfather is cold and indifferent; by the end she realises he has been thinking about her in private all along. Evidence required for at least one point: e.g. 'She had assumed, somehow, that he must simply not care' (beginning) and 'He's been making them... Every single year' (end). One clear piece of evidence earns the mark if both impressions are contrasted.
- 1 mark - Similarity: in both cases, Mira has never met her grandfather and he remains physically absent throughout the passage. Evidence: 'She had never met the man who lived here' (beginning); his continued physical absence at the close, when her mother says nothing and he is not there in person, shows this has not changed. Accept any clearly expressed similarity with reference to the text.
- 1 mark - A developed comparison that brings both points together: e.g. although Mira's understanding of her grandfather's absence changes entirely - from assumed neglect to discovered devotion - the fact of his physical absence is constant throughout; what changes is what she understands that absence to mean. The pupil must connect the similarity and difference, not merely list them, to earn this mark.
- *Full-mark model answer:* A key difference between the beginning and the end is that Mira starts by

believing her grandfather does not care about her - she 'had assumed, somehow, that he must simply not care' - but by the end she discovers he has been carving a bird for her every single year, which shows hidden love. However, there is also a similarity: in both cases Edmund is physically absent and Mira has never met him. What changes is not the fact of his absence but what she understands it to mean. At the start she takes his absence as proof of indifference; at the end she realises he was silently devoted to her all along.

7. (3 marks) - summary

- *Rule:* 3 marks = 3 key points in own words, within the word limit. Descriptive detail scores nothing.
- *Accept (1 mark each):*
- 1 mark - Mira finds a large number of carved wooden birds filling the workshop. Own words required; descriptions of individual birds, their colours, smells, or the quality of the light score nothing.
- 1 mark - She finds a group of five birds kept apart from the rest, each one labelled with her own name.
- 1 mark - She realises her grandfather has been thinking about her and making something for her every year, despite having been absent from her life.
- *Full-mark model answer:* Mira discovers that her grandfather's workshop is full of carefully carved wooden birds. She then finds a group of five birds set apart from the rest, each one carrying a label with her own name. This makes her realise that, despite his long absence, her grandfather has been privately thinking about her and making something for her every year.

8. (2 marks) - inference

- *Rule:* 2 marks = inference + evidence + explanation. Stating the inference alone scores 1 at most.
- *Key quote:* "her face held a complicated expression that Mira had no word for yet"
- *Accept (1 mark each):*
- 1 mark - Inference: Mira's mother feels deeply emotional and conflicted - a complex mixture of feelings such as grief, regret, guilt, or love, not simple sadness. Stating only 'sad' or 'upset' earns this mark only if the complexity of the emotion is clearly acknowledged.
- 1 mark - Evidence and explanation: 'her face held a complicated expression that Mira had no word for yet' shows feelings that go beyond simple emotions - the word 'complicated' implies layers of adult feeling connected to her own history with her estranged father. 'Pulled Mira against her without a word' shows she is too overcome to speak. The pupil must both reference evidence AND explain what it reveals about the mother's inner state to earn this second mark.
- *Full-mark model answer:* I can infer that Mira's mother feels a deep, complicated mixture of emotions - probably love, sadness, and regret all at once. The text tells us 'her face held a complicated expression that Mira had no word for yet', which shows her feelings are too layered and adult for Mira to fully understand. The fact that she 'pulled Mira against her without a word' suggests she is too overwhelmed to speak, showing that the discovery of the birds has stirred up powerful feelings about the years of separation from her father.